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Section Title(S)

CHAPTER 2 INVESTMENT IN MARRIAGE • MARRIAGE NEGOTIATION AND THE MARRIAGE DEBT

Table 1 The increase of polygyny with age

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The developing relationship between fathers and sons is elaborated in later chapters. At this point, it is useful to outline the process of marriage negotiation by an elder who is old enough to combine the roles of negotiator and suitor in arranging his own marriages.

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MARRIAGE NEGOTIATION AND THE MARRIAGE DEBT

Marriage in Matapato transforms a girl's whole existence. As a child, she avoids her father and, for instance, must leave the hut before he can enter. She bows her head submissively to all other elders to palm in greeting. She learns to associate elderhood with a mystical domain of power that resides in knowledge and knowing what is best. It is the elders, and especially her father, who determine her marriage to a man who is normally at least twice her age, and occasionally even four times or more. Her removal to a totally new and strange milieu is an awesome prospect to which she has been conditioned from her earliest years. She is offered no alternative other than to accept her obligation to honour her father's choice with his blessing or to risk his anger, which could have the effect of a curse.

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She might be eight years old when a prospective husband first registers his suit with some small gift to her mother known as 'the anointment' (*esiret*):

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some butter, a bracelet, and nowadays tea and sugar. This transaction is a women's affair, and it is treated as a joke at the girl's expense. The suitor discreetly approaches one of the village wives to be his courier, perhaps a clan 'sister' or the wife of an age mate. In an unguarded moment, she calls over the girl and taking her by surprise, traces a smear of the butter from the bridge of her nose to her crown. Realising what has occurred, the girl is expected to rage. She snatches at leaves or grass or anything on hand to wipe off the butter, while the other women and even girls laugh at her. Then, more solemnly, the courier and another wife,  27 wearing their ritual finery and carrying staves, process round the outside of the village as a delegation to the mother's hut to present her with the gifts. The tea is shared by everyone in celebration except the girl. There is a belief that if she has any part of this gift she will lose her reason. The episode is repeated with each successive suitor. The more bracelets the mother has, the greater her credit for having brought up daughters that are so highly sought after.

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